

Two Tales of One City: Fantasy Proneness, Authenticity, and Loyalty of On-Screen Tourism Destinations

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Abstract

On-screen tourism destinations provide tourists with a mixture of reality and mass-media experience. This study builds a conceptual framework of authenticity evaluating the relationship between fantasy proneness, authenticity, and destination loyalty. It is among the first to compare perceived authenticity of dual images of a destination, both the film location and the story's setting. Using *Game of Thrones* and the city of Dubrovnik as a case, it applies a mixed method of interviews followed by a main survey with both closed- and open-ended questions. The primary findings show that the relationship between authenticity of the film location (Dubrovnik) and loyalty is positive, but such relationship is insignificant for the authenticity of the story's setting (King's Landing). This investigation enriches our understanding of the complex assessments of authenticity and expands the theory of imagination by evaluating the effects of fantasy proneness on perceived authenticity in the context of on-screen tourism.

Keywords

authenticity, fantasy proneness, on-screen tourism, heritage site

Introduction

Life has become stagecraft—a blending of reality and mass-media experience.

(Rose and Wood 2005, p. 284)

This quote from Rose and Wood points out the crucial influence of mass media (such as journalism, film and television) in modern life. *Game of Thrones*, an American fantasy drama television series, tells stories about alliances and conflicts between noble families who are fighting for the throne of the Seven Kingdoms. This entirely fictional drama has its own fictional history, culture, and language. The series was filmed at several locations, such as Northern Ireland, Canada, Croatia, and Iceland. The episodes set in the capital city of the Seven Kingdoms, named King's Landing, were filmed in the Croatian city Dubrovnik. When the television series became popular, the city started to tell two tales. One tale was about Dubrovnik, and the other was about King's Landing. The two tales provided tourists with a mixture of reality and mass-media experiences. The two tales of this destination have led tourists to assess it in terms of two streams of authenticity, as they compare the “real” Dubrovnik and the “real” King's Landing. Conceptualizing authenticity

within on-screen tourism is of particular importance mainly because this type of destination shows unique dual-image attributes which leads to more complex interpretations of authenticity.

Perceived authenticity is likely to lead to tourist visitations (Bryce et al. 2015). Although research on the connections between authenticity and other factors has started to gain popularity, the different types of authenticity that can be perceived in the same on-screen tourism destination have not been well examined (Yi et al. 2018). This study contributes to the literature by extending previous discussions of different

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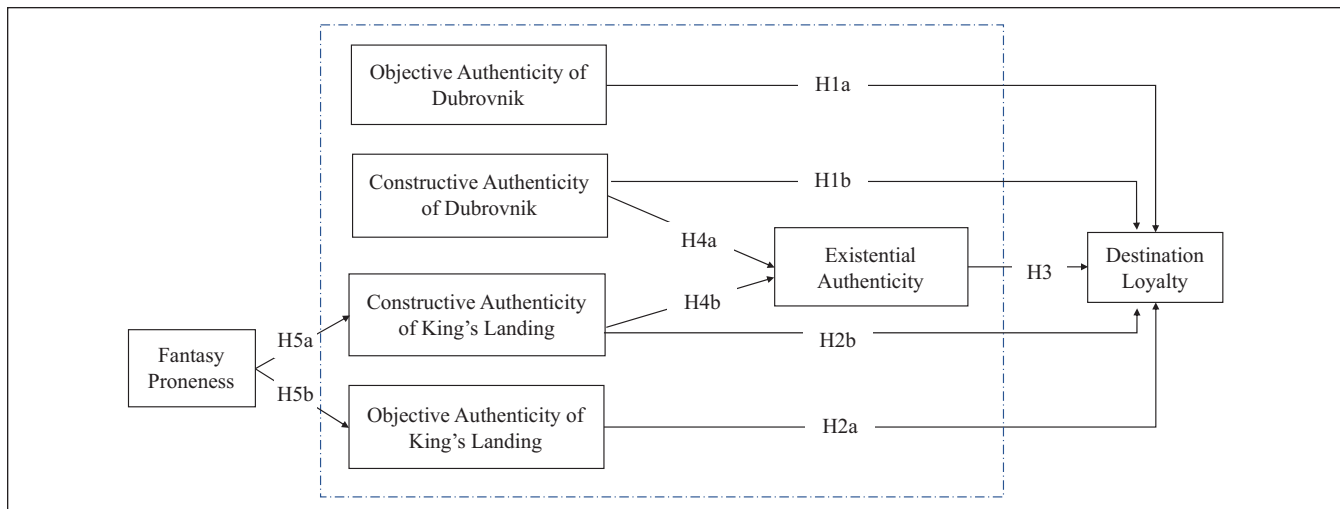


Figure 1. Conceptual research model.

types of authenticity to an on-screen tourism context. Previous studies have discussed tourist experiences that involve the blending of imagination derived from mass-media with the images of landscapes and cultures that are derived from real places (e.g., Rose and Wood 2005; Buchmann, Moore, and Fisher 2010). It is worth further exploring various types of authenticity that are experienced through combining the images generated from both imagined and real places. This study explores how different types of perceived authenticity regarding images of King's Landing and the "real" Dubrovnik influence tourist loyalty.

Tourism activities that are elicited by fantasy dramas and films are linked to the capacity for imagination (Salazar 2012). People with stronger imaginative abilities are more likely to immerse themselves in a drama's settings. People who are highly fantasy prone are more inclined to be involved in imaginary activities (Merckelbach, Horselenberg, and Muris 2001) such as paranormal experiences (Spanos et al. 1993), acceptance of pseudomemories (Hyman and Billings 1998), and tourism activities (Y. Wang et al. 2019). A brochure for the *Game of Thrones* walking tour in Dubrovnik explained, "You'll climb the city walls that were attacked by the Baratheons in the 1st series. Let your imagination run free, as you envision some of the scenes that were filmed here." Tourists' imaginary activities may involve constructing the authenticity of film locations, based on their perceptions regarding the genuineness of scenes found at the location, such as "the city walls" in the previous example. It is therefore plausible to assume that on-screen tourists are to some extent involved in imaginary activities linked to fantasy dramas/films. Although fantasy proneness has been studied in relation to various phenomena, the relationship between fantasy proneness and tourists' perceived authenticity in the context of on-screen tourism is unknown.

This study aims to build and test a conceptual framework of authenticity in which the relationship between the

key relevant influential factor, fantasy proneness, and the key outcome of authentic experiences, destination loyalty, are evaluated in the context of an on-screen tourism heritage site. Special emphasis is placed on examining the dual images presented at a particular on-screen site (i.e., the images of the traditional heritage destination and of the on-screen destination). This conceptual framework can be seen as a useful complement to other consumer-based models (such as the value and quality model) as it allows a more comprehensive understanding of tourist experiences (Kolar and Zabkar 2010). The study explores the two potential sources of authenticity perceived by tourists in Dubrovnik, who commonly view the site as both a World Heritage City and as the fictional capital city featured in *Game of Thrones*, King's Landing. Based on previous literature and a series of interviews, the authors propose a dual authenticity model (see Figure 1).

Tourism managers, marketers, and policy makers are facing new challenges and opportunities in these unprecedented COVID-19 pandemic times and beyond. The year of 2020 has proven particularly difficult for tourism businesses as tourist numbers and tourism revenue dramatically decrease as a result of this event. Despite the restrictions on travel, tourism demand for future travel continues to exist and may grow. During the pandemic quarantine, people have had more time than ever to stay at home and watch television shows and films using, for example, streaming services. As a result, on-screen tourism and fantasy proneness have a potential to drive future travel decisions to a much greater extent than before. It is thus particularly important for tourism suppliers to understand people's perceptions toward on-screen tourism and how fantasy proneness affects their perceptions. Therefore, studying tourists' perceptions of authenticity in the case of these two tales of a city (i.e., fictional and factual) can provide implications for managers, marketers, and policy makers and their destination-promotion strategies.

There are three theoretical contributions of this research. First, it is among the first to investigate the dual images presented at on-screen tourism destinations. Specifically, it examines whether and to what extent the authenticity of these dual images is related to destination loyalty. The combination of the actual place and the imagined place would augment the tourist space (Sandvik and Waade 2008) which makes research on tourists' authenticity interesting and important. A better understanding of the interaction of two images at one destination can contribute to the creation of destination marketing and management strategies. Second, the study contributes to theoretical understanding of authenticity by analyzing the relationships among three types of authenticity at an on-screen tourism destination. Third, the study enriches the theory of imagination by evaluating the effects of fantasy proneness on perceived authenticity in the context of on-screen tourism. Methodologically, this research applies a mixed-method approach in the form of interviews followed by a main survey study with both closed- and open-ended questions, which enhances the reliability and validity of the construct operationalization and triangulates the results.

Literature and Background Review

On-Screen Tourism

On-screen tourism can be defined as tourism activities associated with visiting a destination that has been used as a filming location for a film or television show (Buchmann, Moore, and Fisher 2010). Research within the field, presented in the last two decades, has moved from focusing on specific cases (i.e., screen productions or destinations) to cross-case analysis and conceptual development (e.g., Beeton 2005; Larson, Lundberg, and Lexhagen 2013; Roesch 2009; Van Es and Reijnders 2016). Literature on on-screen tourism has used a destination approach, such as the commodification of place and place making (e.g., Naef 2018), destination images (e.g., Williams-Burnett, Skinner, and Fallon 2018), and impact (e.g., Li et al. 2017), and a tourist-approach including tourists' experiences, motivations, involvement, and decision making (e.g., Bowyer 2017; Lee et al. 2018; Lundberg and Lexhagen 2012; Kim, Kim, and Petrick 2019), and flows (e.g., Kim et al. 2007). The literature offers dynamic and multilayered interpretations by both stakeholders and tourists of on-screen productions, allowing the creation of new meanings, transformation of place, and perception of authentic experiences and products (Lundberg, Ziakas, and Morgan 2018).

On-screen tourism destinations are usually described as settings and locations. The former refers to places where the story of the screen production is set while the latter refers to where it was filmed (Tooke and Baker 1996). In our case, Dubrovnik is the (TV series) location of the fictional setting King's Landing. Having a fictional setting at a (at least

partly) real location may lead to local dissonance, that is, the perceptual differences between where a story takes place and where it is filmed. When tourists visit a film location, they might not recognize what they have seen on screen and thus a discrepancy between what they expected to see and the actual experience arises which may affect the overall perception of authenticity of place (Frost 2009).

In fantasy-themed on-screen productions, displacement refers to the phenomenon whereby a film/television series is shot in a real place that is presented as a fictional setting. This displacement can cause a potentially conflicting relationship between the authenticity of the film experience and the film production process, which involves "the proliferation of simulacra and the hyperreal" (Buchmann, Moore, and Fisher 2010, p. 233). In addition, tourists' experiences involve mixtures of perceptions regarding fictional settings (e.g., "Middle-Earth" in *The Lord of the Rings* films) and the physical locations of filming (e.g., places in modern New Zealand). The danger may arise that the tourist spending on created landscape and cultures may replace real histories and cultures (Tzanelli 2006). Therefore, the story's setting may play a more important role than the filming location in attracting tourists (Tooke and Baker 1996). This study examines this interaction of the story's setting and the filming location particularly in the context of fantasy film/television series tourism.

Authenticity in Tourism

Authenticity has been an important topic in tourism research as tourists always look for authentic experiences (Ramkissoon and Uysal 2014). In earlier debates, some researchers described tourism experiences as inauthentic (e.g., Boorstin 1964), and others believed that authenticity that tourists searched for were staged (e.g., MacCannell 1973). N. Wang (1999) explained three main forms of authenticity: objective, constructive and existential. The notion of objective authenticity developed from the original meaning of authenticity in a museum setting. In the tourism context, *objective authenticity* refers to authentic experiences as perceived by tourists. The term implies that toured objects can be perceived as authentic even though they are not, which can be explained as an outcome of staged authenticity (N. Wang 1999). Objective authenticity also aligns with the understanding of authenticity as primitive. Trilling (1972) proposed that authenticity should be viewed as being free from influences by modern and industrial life and commoditization. Tourists also seek for natural and primitive experience at a destination (Cohen 1988). Replication of historical objects, culture, and environment is a way to showcase objective authenticity, and what matters is the depth of experience (Hall 2007), that is, the deeper the experience of replication, the closer it could be to the original.

The concepts of constructive and existential authenticity arose in the context of postmodernism, in which various

thinkers have questioned whether genuineness exists, or have argued that actual, genuine, and objective reality do not exist (Zhu 2012). In this context, it is believed that the real can only be socially constructed, by individuals or groups with particular interests and agendas, according to their own interpretations (Waitt 2000). The term *constructive authenticity* concerns perceptions regarding the genuineness of objects. Such perceptions can reflect tourists' beliefs, expectations, and even dreams (N. Wang 1999). Constructive authenticity allows for the creation of tradition through which the authenticity of toured objects is reconstructed by different stakeholders, including tourists and destinations (Taylor 2001).

Objective and constructive authenticity can also be described as object-related authenticity (Wang 1999). This term mainly concerns object attributes, and existential authenticity is more related to activity-related authenticity. Existential experience, which is more subjective, is commonly described as a liminal process, during which tourist activities can activate personal feelings, such as the feeling of being more genuine and freely expressed (N. Wang 1999; Reisinger and Steiner 2006). Tourists, instead of looking for genuine objects, paid more attention to true self. Tourism, as a nonordinary activity, becomes a means of escaping from daily life (N. Wang 1999), especially for tourists who suffer from negative feelings such as anxiety and depression (Zhou et al. 2012).

Cohen and Cohen (2012) identified two models of authentication. Cool authentication involves the act of declaring the originality and genuineness of an object. Hot authentication is a "process of creating, preserving and reinforcing an object's, site's or event's authenticity" (1,300). Accreditation is crucial to cool authentication, in which genuineness is ascribed to "the physical attributes of a geographic area and/or the culture of its inhabitants" (Cohen and Cohen 2012, p. 1299). A typical example is provided by the World Heritage Sites certified by the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. Cool authentication is more likely to occur during objective (object-related) authenticity experiences (Lau 2010). Hot authentication involves tourists' becoming part of the process, and it is relevant to existential authenticity, which is based on expressing people's identity (Cohen and Cohen 2012; Steiner and Reisinger 2006).

Previous studies have measured tourists' perceived authenticity regarding heritage sites (Waitt 2000). Objective authenticity can be used to determine the extent that an attraction can represent the past (Ivanovic 2014). This concept presumes that a standard that judges genuineness can be set up to justify a World Heritage Site's claim to historicity from the perspective of objective authenticity (N. Wang 1999). In terms of constructive authenticity, a heritage site's historicity can be reflected by symbolic representations. For example, South African heritage sites can be seen as iconic attractions that evoke authentic tourist experiences (Ivanovic 2014). Existential authenticity concerns

feelings of connectedness to human history and civilization, and feelings of enjoyment experienced during a visit (Kolar and Zabkar 2010). Heritage sites can be seen as a platform for tourists to associate with their authentic self (Chhabra, Healy, and Sills 2003).

Authenticity and On-Screen Tourism

In the context of literary tourism, tourists intend to travel for both the writers and the characters described in the novels. As a result, "the boundaries between fact and fiction, the real and the metaphorical, thus become increasingly blurred and increasingly indistinct" (Tetley 1998, p. 14). This would make the concept of authenticity more relevant but complex. Two types of authenticity, factual and fictional authenticity at literary sites, have been distinguished by Tetley (1998) explaining that visitors were likely to search for facts of history or author's information or authenticity of fiction. For example, when tourists visit Haworth, they may want to experience authentic landscape described in *Jane Eyre* and to explore the writer, Charlotte Bronte's original house. Likewise, when visiting an on-screen tourism destination, tourists may also simultaneously perceive the objective authenticity of both a film setting and a real location (Rittichainuwat et al. 2018). Compared to literary tourism travelers, on-screen visitors may perceive authenticity very differently in that (1) they may not pay much attention to information of the on-screen story's author as factual authenticity; (2) images such as scenery and landscape in both film settings and real locations may play a more prominent role.

Buchmann, Moore, and Fisher (2010) evaluated tourist experience at film-induced tourism destinations, using the case of *The Lord of the Rings*, which was filmed in New Zealand, and found film tourism sites involve a combination of two images. These authors showed the importance of physical places for invoking existential authenticity in the film tourism experience. They discovered that although the initial motivation of some travelers to New Zealand was to experience the fantastic Middle-Earth, other travelers viewed visiting the film site for *The Lord of the Rings* as an excuse to experience the real New Zealand, and that many tourists experienced a mixture of these motives. Similarly, Dubrovnik was famous as a Croatian tourist destination before *Game of Thrones* was filmed there. Therefore, this television series may provide an extra reason for people to visit.

In the case of *The Lord of the Rings* films, produced in New Zealand, tourists may experience a merger of the fantasy place with the actual place. However, this type of integration between King's Landing and Dubrovnik could be more difficult for tourists, as both the fantasy world and the real place have their own distinctive histories and cultures. Therefore, this study explores tourists' experiences at a film site that combines two tales in one city, that is, the story of the *Game of Thrones*, the television series, and the story of the historical Republic of Ragusa in Dubrovnik. It investigates the

ways that tourists evaluate the authenticity of both King's Landing and the real Dubrovnik. In other words, how tourists perceive authentic characteristics of the film location and the story setting.

Fantasy Proneness

Fantasy proneness is a concept proposed by Wilson and Barber (1983) to describe people who can be labeled as habitual fantasizers (Merckelbach, Horselenberg, and Muris 2001). Fantasy proneness has been found to be associated with various phenomena observed in psychological or clinical research, such as paranormal experiences, UFO sightings (Spanos et al. 1993), and pseudomemories (Hyman and Billings 1998). Fantasy proneness in the context of tourism also deserves a careful examination. High levels of fantasy proneness, which are often relevant to negative clinical outcomes such as neuroticism and dissociation (Naylor and Simonds 2015), could also be related to more positive outcomes in the tourism context. For instance, Y. Wang et al. (2019) found that fantasy proneness moderated the relationship between the unique selling proposition levels of tourism slogans and mental imagery, which eventually influences a tourist's travel intentions.

Fantasy proneness is highly relevant in the context of on-screen productions, and especially fantasy films/television shows. Highly fantasy-prone persons are more likely to fantasize, create vivid imagery, and daydream: "They (people) can experience anything in fantasy . . . and emotions such as fright and joy can be experienced . . . when immersed in fantasy, they do not ask whether their experiences are real" (Wilson and Barber 1983, p. 352). Highly fantasy-prone tourists tend to use their imaginations and move between the fantasies evoked by film locations and the perceptions evoked by real locations (Bacon, Walsh, and Martin 2013). Therefore, on-screen tourism sites commonly set up spaces devoted to imagination, fantasy, and dreaming to allow tourists to experience feeling apart from the mundane world (Salazar 2012).

King's Landing and Dubrovnik

Because of filming the capital city of *Game of Thrones*, King's Landing, Dubrovnik has taken dual images. Both King's Landing and Dubrovnik have its own distinctive history, culture, people, and their ways of living. Dubrovnik was selected as it presents a good case to explore authenticity, given that its fictional *Game of Thrones* world is based on fantasy with limited anchoring in the real Dubrovnik. Furthermore, the impressive size and impact of the *Game of Thrones* phenomenon on current popular culture discourse and travel to locations around Europe, of which Dubrovnik/King's Landing is one of the main destinations, support the selection of the case under study.

Game of Thrones, which is an American fantasy drama described as medieval realism, is based on George R. R. Martin's legendary book series *A Song of Ice and Fire*. This series features several plot lines and fictional kingdoms. One of the main story arcs focuses on the political intrigue associated with the power struggles for the Iron Throne. The throne and the royal family are located in King's Landing, and this site was primarily filmed in Dubrovnik.

Dubrovnik is a well-known tourism destination and World Heritage Site located on the Adriatic coastline. The city has historically been based on maritime trade, and in the thirteenth century it was established as a prominent sea power in the Mediterranean. Tourism has been central in the post-Balkan war infrastructural and economic recovery, and the city's status as a World Heritage Site has been important to help "unify and anchor identities within the new geopolitical context following the turbulent 1990s war" (Mutzfeldt 2019, p. 9).

The old town of Dubrovnik has attracted millions of tourists, and this increase in visitations during the last few years has been largely attributed to the success of *Game of Thrones* and the city's association with the fictional capital of the series, King's Landing (Tkalec, Zilic, and Recher 2017). In 2017, *Game of Thrones* was reportedly responsible for half of Dubrovnik's increase in annual tourism (Santora 2018). As a result, Croatian destination marketing organizations saw an opportunity to capitalize on the city's association with the television show and to allow tourists to experience authenticity at on-screen location sites in Dubrovnik (Šegota 2018). Most of the tourist tours in the city are organized by small tourism businesses, and they commonly focus on merging tourists' experiences of Dubrovnik's local history with displaying the city's association with *Game of Thrones*. These businesses are seeking to address tourists' need to experience both the historical (Dubrovnik) and the mediated (King's Landing) narratives (Šegota 2018, n.p.).

Conceptual Research Model and Hypotheses

In the assessment of authenticity, it is crucial to analyze the precedents and behavioral consequences of perceived authenticity (Ye, Xiao, and Zhou 2018). Based on previous literature and interviews, this study proposes a theoretical model (see Figure 1) for investigating the relationships among (a) fantasy proneness, an important antecedent that is relevant to on-screen tourism destinations; (b) three types of authenticity perceived in the dual (film-site and real site) images of the tourism destination; and (c) destination loyalty, the key outcome of such perceptions.

Authenticity and Destination Loyalty

Loyalty is considered as an important topic as loyal tourists will commit toward tourism products and destination and

pursue loyal behavior such as revisit and recommendation (Liat, Mansori, and Huei 2014; Fu 2019). Revisiting behavior and recommendations to others are the two key items that were used to measure destination loyalty (Kolar and Zabkar 2010; Yi et al. 2017). In consumer behavior studies, perceived authenticity has been considered as a crucial factor to influence tourists' behavior (Grayson and Martinec 2004; Gilmore and Pine 2007). Therefore, the investigation of the relationship between authenticity and loyalty has attracted scholars' attention (e.g., Kolar and Zabkar 2010; Ramkissoon and Uysal 2011; Bryce et al. 2015; Fu 2019).

Although its relationship with authenticity has been well discussed in the literature, mixed results have been found. Some studies have reported significantly positive linkages between various types of authenticity and destination loyalty. For example, it has been found that both object-based authenticity and existential authenticity are positively related to destination loyalty in the cultural heritage context (Kolar and Zabkar 2010; Ramkissoon and Uysal 2011; Bryce et al. 2015). It can be explained that an authentic experience, such as "representation of a scenic landscape" and "having a documented history" would generate a successful consumption of the cultural destination, which leads to future behavioral intention (Ramkissoon and Uysal 2011). When tourists achieve existential state of being, it is likely to induce their positive emotion, which will encourage loyal behaviors (Fu 2019). However, other studies have failed to find a significant influence of authenticity on loyalty. For example, Zhou, Zhang, and Edelman (2013) did not find any significant correlation between existential authenticity and destination loyalty in the Chinese calligraphic landscape context. The inconsistent findings in the literature imply that the existence and the extent of relationships between different types of authenticity and loyalty may be due to cultural and contextual aspects (Bryce et al. 2015; Yi et al. 2018), and thus these factors deserve further exploration. Investigating the relationships between different types of authenticity and loyalty can provide a more comprehensive and in-depth understanding of authenticity, thus, this study proposes the following hypotheses:

Hypothesis 1a: The objective authenticity of Dubrovnik is positively associated with destination loyalty.

Hypothesis 1b: The constructive authenticity of Dubrovnik is positively associated with destination loyalty.

Hypothesis 2a: The objective authenticity of King's Landing is positively associated with destination loyalty.

Hypothesis 2b: The constructive authenticity of King's Landing is positively associated with destination loyalty.

Hypothesis 3: Existential authenticity is positively associated with destination loyalty.

Constructive and Existential Authenticity

This study further investigates the relationships between different types of authenticity. Modern tourists become more

sophisticated and thus it is necessary to investigate the links between existential and objective authenticity (Ramkissoon and Uysal 2014). Using cultural tourism sites in Mauritius as a case study, Ramkissoon and Uysal (2014) explored authenticity as a cocreator of tourism experience and they found that tourists evaluate authenticity of a destination by combining their fulfilment of their authentic self and consumption of authentic objects. As an existential experience is generated from tourism objects and contexts (Kolar and Zabkar 2010), tourists' states of experiencing authenticity are likely to be triggered by authentic tourism experiences or by appreciation of "real" objects (N. Wang 1999; Yi et al. 2018). Previous studies have found that existential authenticity is somewhat reliant on perceived authenticity (Yi et al. 2018). Kolar and Zabkar (2010) suggested that existential authenticity, which is linked to tourists' feelings and emotions, is likely to be directly triggered by constructive authenticity in cultural heritage settings. It is believed that travel can create a setting where tourists can become more self (Amey 2018). On-screen tourism destinations also provide an unusual environment, different from tourists' normal daily life, where they can search for and experience their perceived authenticity. This may further fulfil the existential state of being, that is, pursuing self-realization or self-satisfaction.

Therefore, the following hypotheses are proposed:

Hypothesis 4a: The constructive authenticity of Dubrovnik is positively associated with the existential authenticity of Dubrovnik.

Hypothesis 4b: The constructive authenticity of King's Landing is positively associated with the existential authenticity of King's Landing.

Fantasy Proneness and Authenticity

Fantasy proneness can be used to describe the levels of capacity for imagining and to measure imaginative involvement (Naylor and Simonds 2015). Fantasy proneness is highly relevant to the on-screen tourism context as fantasy-prone tourists tend to imagine fictitious situations, including those created in fantasy movies, which sometimes allow them to mentally escape reality (Bacon, Walsh, and Martin 2013). It is discovered that highly fantasy-prone people scored higher in measures of fantasy, imagination, and creativity than less fantasy-prone people (Lynn and Rhue 1986).

It is important to identify the key factors that affect authenticity in a specific context. Existing studies have examined various factors that can influence perceived authenticity in the tourism context, such as cultural motivations (Kolar and Zabkar 2010), attitudes (Zhou, Zhang, and Edelman 2013), and imagination (Bryce et al. 2015). In Bryce et al.'s (2015) study, it was found that heritage-related behaviors (e.g., "watched a television show related to Japan's heritage") were important influencing factors for Japanese object-based authentic offerings. People intend to blend visual images of a place they watched on screen with

their imagination (Amey 2018), which implies that imagination would play a role in forming a perceived authenticity of that place. When a destination has dual images of the real world and the fictional world shown in the on-screen products, imaginative element is crucial for tourists' experience in connecting the fictional world with the real one (Waysdorf and Reijnders 2017). Imagination is closely associated with fantasy proneness (Thomson and Jaque 2011). Schelleman-Offermans and Merckelbach (2010, p. 247) found that "high fantasy-prone people are good in creating a sense of authenticity." This ability may be attributed to their capacity for imagining. In the context of on-screen tourism, and particularly fantasy television shows-related tourism, tourists' level of fantasy-proneness is likely to be one of the key factors influencing perceived authenticity regarding a film location. Therefore, we might reasonably expect that tourists who are highly fantasy-prone are more inclined to experience authenticity at a film site.

The following hypotheses are proposed:

Hypothesis 5a: Fantasy proneness is positively associated with the objective authenticity of King's Landing.

Hypothesis 5b: Fantasy proneness is positively associated with the constructive authenticity of King's Landing.

Method

Research Design

This research employs a mixed methods approach containing a pre-stage study followed by a main study. First, it conducted a pre-stage study, that is, semistructured interviews which contributed to the subject familiarization and scale verification. Specifically, the pre-stage study focused on exploring whether and how tourists perceive authenticity of both the real place and the film location. Second, the main study containing both closed- and open-ended survey questions was conducted. Text analysis of responses to open-ended questions in the survey further validated the key authenticity measurement items that brought a deeper understanding of respondents' perceptions of authenticity. Based on closed-ended questions, it adopted a positivist approach that used quantitative methods to explore the relationships between different types of authenticity and behavioral intentions in the context of the dual images of on-screen destinations.

Pre-stage Study

Following an essentialist epistemological approach to acquiring subject familiarization and scale verification (Bryman and Becker 2012), semistructured interviews as a pre-stage study were conducted in April 2018 prior to the main study. Such an approach has been widely used by other researchers in the field of tourism and hospitality (Biran et al. 2014). The interview guide included two parts: interviewees' demographic background and their perceptions regarding the

authenticity and their destination loyalty. Three themes of interview questions were developed: (1) interviewees' perceptions regarding the authenticity of Dubrovnik; (2) interviewees' perceptions regarding the authenticity of King's Landing; and (3) how these perceptions influenced their destination loyalty. One author interviewed 14 participants through social media tools including Skype and WeChat. On average, each interview lasted approximately 45 minutes. For the purpose of the study, only people who had visited Dubrovnik in the past seven years and had watched at least part of the *Game of Thrones* series were eligible to participate. In selecting the participants, purposive sampling and snowball sampling were used to gain the advantage of selecting individuals who possessed knowledge and information regarding the topic under study (Cresswell 2007; Biran et al. 2014). The sample consisted of 7 males and females, respectively, who were between 18 and 50 years old. The interviewees were recruited through authors' networks.

The main results revealed that interviewees were able to perceive two sets of authenticity, that is, authentic characteristics of Dubrovnik and King's Landing. When tourists were experiencing the facts of the original sites, such as history and people's lifestyle, this may encourage tourists to trace the imaginary places where fictional characters existed (Amey 2018). One interviewee said, "I enjoyed my walk along the streets and city walls. I liked castles and walls, and those show this city's real past . . . I especially searched for the locations where famous scenes in *Game of Thrones* were filmed, such as 'Walk of Shame' and the 'Royal Wedding.' Those sites made me feel that characters in *Games of Thrones* seemed to be around and things seemed to be happening in King's Landing." This indicates that respondents can identify the differences in authenticity between Dubrovnik and King's Landing. In fact, tourists would at some point compare the real place with the film location (Amey 2018). One interviewee expressed that "I found the natural scenery in Dubrovnik and that in King's Landing have some in common, typically the blue sea."

Regarding destination loyalty questions, many respondents replied that they would spend their holidays in Dubrovnik again. One interviewee mentioned, "Why not? I love to visit Dubrovnik again as I like its old town and blue sea. It's a good option for holiday. Feel very relaxed." Some respondents had shared their experiences and photos of visiting Dubrovnik with friends. These interviews were conducted in the pre-stage of the study for the purpose of gaining contextual insights and informing the design of the main study. The results generated from the interviews have been briefly summarized above as the focus of the paper is on the main study in the following sections.

Main Study

Based on the pre-stage study and the literature review, the main stage applied the survey method to test the model presented in Figure 1. An online questionnaire was designed

Table 1. Sample Distribution.

Gender	n (%)	Age	n (%)	Education Background	n (%)
Female	215 (46.7)	18–24	33 (7.2)	High school or under	74 (16.1)
Male	245 (53.2)	25–34	105 (22.7)	College or university student	91 (19.8)
		35–44	83 (18.1)	College or university graduate	171 (73.2)
		45–54	81 (17.6)	Graduate student and over	124 (26.7)
		55+	158 (34.3)		
Annual Household Income	n (%)	Number of Visits to Dubrovnik	n (%)	Fan of <i>Game of Thrones</i> ?	
Less than £15,000	21 (4.6)	Once	316 (68.5)		
£15,000–£25,999	44 (9.6)	Twice	106 (23.1)		Mean: 5.710
£26,000–£34,999	71 (15.4)	Three times	28 (6.1)		Standard
£35,000–£49,999	90 (19.6)	Four times+	10 (2.1)		deviation: 1.551
£50,000–£69,999	96 (20.9)				
£70,000 or more	106 (23.0)				
Prefer not to say	32 (6.8)				

containing both closed- and open-ended questions. Open-ended questionnaires have been commonly used in tourism and hospitality research. For example, Arnon and Reichel (2009) found that open-ended questions can be seen as a useful and effective tool that can allow the respondents to freely reflect on their authentic answers.

In this research, using open-ended questions provided a deeper understanding of the respondents' perceptions of authenticity, which are the focal concerns of the study. To maintain the simplicity of the survey, two open-ended questions were included: (a) "In your opinion, what is (are) the most important authentic characteristic(s) of Dubrovnik?" and (b) "In your opinion, what is (are) the most important authentic characteristic(s) of King's Landing, which is the capital city in *Game of Thrones*?" The respondents were asked to provide up to three answers for each question. Although relatively short answers were obtained, the use of open-ended questions was sufficient and effective to capture respondents' opinions.

The responses to open-ended questions can also be used to further validate the measurement items. The survey questions corresponded to each of the four items for measuring perceptions of the objective authenticity of Dubrovnik and King's Landing, and they were based on both the previous literature and findings from the interview stage. Additionally, the use of open-ended questions followed the process proposed by Arnon and Reichel (2009), which is to arrange the open-ended questions before the closed-ended ones to avoid affecting the study's credibility through influencing the respondents' free answers to the open-ended questions.

Sample

The survey was distributed to a Survey Sampling International (SSI) panel of UK adults in October 2018, and 596 usable responses were obtained. The first season of *Game of Thrones* was released in 2011 and then one season was

released each year after that. The research focuses on the dual image of Dubrovnik and King's Landing in the *Game of Thrones*. Therefore, filter questions were used to ensure that only respondents who had been to Dubrovnik in the past seven years and had watched at least part of the *Game of Thrones* series were eligible. After removing outlier values and checking the quality of the responses to both the closed- and open-ended questions, 460 valid questionnaires remained. Respondents' demographic background is provided in Table 1, indicating that the sample distribution was reasonably wide.

Measures

All measures items for the constructs in Figure 1 were developed based on previous literature related to the on-screen tourism destination context and on the findings from the interview stage. The questionnaire included four sections: (1) authenticity questions, (2) destination loyalty questions, (3) fantasy proneness questions, and (4) socioeconomic and demographic questions. A 7-point Likert-type scale (ranging from 1 = strongly agree to 7 = strongly disagree) was used for sections 1 and 2. To measure the items in section 3, a scale was developed that ranged from 1 = extremely unlike me to 7 = extremely like me.

Section one included questions regarding the respondents' perceptions of authenticity regarding Dubrovnik and King's Landing. These questions were developed after considering the scales developed by Kolar and Zabkar (2010), Ye, Xiao, and Zhou (2018), Bryce et al. (2015), Lu, Chi, and Liu (2015), Ram, Bjork, and Weidenfeld (2016), and Meng and Choi (2016). The objective authenticity of both Dubrovnik and King's Landing was measured by using four items for each location, and the constructive authenticity of Dubrovnik and of King's Landing was measured by three items for each location. Two items were used to measure existential authenticity, adapting from Yi et al. (2017), Yi et al. (2018), and Ye,

Table 2. Measures, Means and Standard Deviations of the Survey Items.

Constructs	Mean	SD	Kurtosis	Skewness
Objective authenticity of Dubrovnik <i>the characteristics of authenticities of Dubrovnik are . . .</i>				
OAD1—Rich historical heritage in Dubrovnik	1.699	0.908	4.042	1.751
OAD2—Historical architecture (e.g., ports, forts, castles, walls) in Dubrovnik	1.582	0.865	5.803	2.034
OAD3—Natural scenery, such as blue sea beaches in Dubrovnik	1.782	0.943	2.340	1.448
OAD4—The feel, smell, look, and color in Dubrovnik	2.109	1.019	0.929	0.983
Constructive authenticity of Dubrovnik				
CAD1—I can tell the historical character of Dubrovnik during my visit to Dubrovnik	2.161	1.073	0.934	1.025
CAD2—I can tell the features of people living in Dubrovnik during my visit to Dubrovnik	2.771	1.354	−0.409	0.585
CAD3—I can tell the culture of Dubrovnik during my visit to Dubrovnik	2.479	1.256	0.574	0.883
Objective authenticity of King's Landing <i>the characteristics of authenticities of King's Landing are . . .</i>				
OAK1—Old buildings shown in King's Landing	2.307	1.106	2.043	1.163
OAK2—Landscape shown in King's Landing	2.301	1.089	0.883	0.874
OAK3—Main characters and fictional figures associated with King's Landing	2.636	1.205	0.001	0.608
OAK4—I associate “conspiracy,” “blood,” and “plots” with King's Landing	2.767	1.249	−0.210	0.455
Constructive authenticity of King's Landing				
CAK1—I can associate with the historical character of King's Landing during my visit to Dubrovnik	2.741	1.382	0.935	0.990
CAK2—I can tell the lifestyle of people living in King's Landing during my visit to Dubrovnik	3.187	1.575	−0.339	0.572
CAK3—I can tell the culture of King's Landing during my visit to Dubrovnik	3.124	1.530	−0.052	0.680
Existential authenticity <i>During my recent visit to Dubrovnik . . .</i>				
EA1—My body is free from the self-control and limitations of daily routines, and I become more self and subjective in its own right	3.481	1.469	−0.046	0.367
EA2—I try to seek extra-mundane or unusual experiences in order to pursue self-realization or self-satisfaction	3.662	1.589	−0.417	0.339
Destination Loyalty				
DL1—I would like to visit Dubrovnik again	1.989	1.919	2.784	1.566
DL2—I would recommend Dubrovnik to my friends	1.878	1.034	3.212	1.609
Fantasy Proneness				
FP1—I daydream and fantasize with some regularity about things that might happen to me	3.634	1.660	−0.590	0.434
FP2—I really get involved with the feelings of the characters in a novel	2.967	1.416	0.669	0.878
FP3—I am usually objective when I watch a movie or play, and I don't often get completely caught up in it (r)	3.869	1.567	−0.950	0.040
FP4—Becoming extremely involved in a good book or movie is somewhat rare for me (r)	3.453	1.767	−0.865	0.407
FP5—After seeing a play or movie, I have felt as though I were one of the characters	3.980	1.687	−0.787	0.220
FP6—When I am reading an interesting story or novel, I imagine how I would feel if the events in the story were happening to me	3.172	1.534	0.283	0.821

Note: The item scales were anchored from 'strongly agree' (1) to 'strongly disagree' (7).

Xiao, and Zhou (2018). Section 2 presented destination loyalty-related questions that were adapted from Kolar and Zabkar (2010). Section 3 included questions concerning fantasy proneness containing six items adapted from Garrido and Schubert (2011). Section 4 asked socioeconomic and demographic questions. Please see Table 2 for the survey items.

Results

The results generated from the main study are discussed in detail in this section. As the survey contains both open- and closed-ended questions, the results regarding the two types of questions are presented in two separate parts in the following.

Table 3. Perceived Authentic Characteristics of Dubrovnik and King's Landing.

Two open-ended questions: In your opinion, what is the most important authentic characteristic(s) of Dubrovnik/KL*?				Two closed-ended questions: Please indicate the extent to which you agree with the following statements – the characteristics of authenticities of Dubrovnik/KL* are:		
Top 5 Categories (authentic characteristics of Dubrovnik)	Concepts	Count of concepts	Ranking	Items (authentic characteristics of Dubrovnik)	Likert Scale 1 = strongly agree . . . 7 = strongly disagree Mean (Standard Deviation)	
1. Architecture and old buildings	Walls, architecture, forts	220	1	1. Historical architecture (e.g., ports, forts, castles, walls) in Dubrovnik	1.699	(0.908)
2. History/historical heritage	History/historical heritage	94	2	2. Rich historical heritage in Dubrovnik	1.582	(0.865)
3. Landscape and scenery	Landscape, scenery, sea, coast, nature	76	3	3. Natural scenery, such as blue sea, beaches in Dubrovnik	1.782	(0.943)
4. City	City, town	72	4	4. The feel, smell, look, and color in Dubrovnik	2.109	(1.019)
5. Look and feel	Look, beauty, weather, views	31	5			
Top 5 Categories (authentic characteristics of KL)	Concepts	Count of concepts	Ranking	Items (authentic characteristics of KL)	Likert Scale 1 = strongly agree 7 = strongly disagree Mean (Standard Deviation)	
1. Architecture	Architecture	123	1	1. Old buildings shown in KL	2.307	(1.106)
2. Landscape and scenery	Landscape, scenery, sea, coastline	98	2	2. The landscape shown in KL	2.301	(1.089)
3. City	City, place, location	36	3	3. Main characters and fictional figures associated with KL	2.636	(1.205)
4. About the story of GoT	Setting, backdrop, thrones, emotions	35	4	4. "Conspiracy," "blood," and "plots" associated with KL	2.767	(1.249)
5. Characters and people	Characters, people	23	5			

*KL is the abbreviation for King's Landing; The first question asks about Dubrovnik and the second question asks about KL.

The open-ended questions were analyzed to triangulate the validity of the authenticity survey items using qualitative thematic analysis and statistical analysis. Following the process applied by Ryan and Ninov (2011), SPSS Modeler Text Analytics was used to extract the concepts and build categories. Following Saldana (2009), two cycles of coding were applied to identify the main categories of open-ended responses. During the first cycle, 460 and 340 concepts were initially generated regarding the perceived authenticity of Dubrovnik and King's Landing, respectively. These concepts were grouped via the function of "building categories," and then merged into 45 and 40 categories (respectively) during the second cycle.

The top five categories are summarized in Table 3. Apart from the category of "city" in both authenticity of Dubrovnik and King's Landing, other four top-ranked categories generated from the responses to open-ended questions matched the four items in the corresponding closed-ended questions.

In addition, the ranking of the four categories measured by the percentage of total count of concepts (see the left section of the Table 3) is the same as the ranking of the items measured by the percentage of respondents selected strongly agree and agree options (see the right section of the Table 3). Specifically, architecture has been ranked as the most important perceived authentic characteristics of Dubrovnik, which is followed by historical heritage, scenery, and the look and feel in Dubrovnik. As to the importance of perceived authentic characteristics of King's Landing, architecture, scenery, and landscape shown in King's Landing are ranked as top two categories, which are followed by the story of *Game of Thrones* (e.g., setting, backdrops, thrones, and emotion) and characters and people. Such results verified the items of the closed-ended questions, which further confirmed the validity of the perceived authenticity measurement items, given that authenticity was the key theme in this study.

Table 4. Assessment of Construct Reliability and Validity.

	Cronbach's Alpha	Composite Reliability	Average Variance Extracted (AVE)
Objective Authenticity of King's Landing (OAK)	0.867	0.867	0.621
Objective Authenticity of Dubrovnik (OAD)	0.874	0.871	0.631
Constructive Authenticity of Dubrovnik (CAD)	0.814	0.819	0.602
Constructive Authenticity of King's Landing (CAK)	0.899	0.899	0.748
Existential Authenticity (EA)	0.827	0.828	0.707
Destination Loyalty (DL)	0.832	0.833	0.715
Fantasy Proneness (FP)	0.820	0.823	0.540

Table 5. Fornell-Larcker Criterion.

	CAD	CAK	EA	FP	DL	OAD	OAK
CAD	0.776						
CAK	0.669	0.864					
EA	0.443	0.553	0.841				
FP	0.343	0.390	0.518	0.735			
DL	0.639	0.400	0.296	0.172	0.845		
OAD	0.648	0.352	0.133	0.087	0.769	0.794	
OAK	0.601	0.781	0.454	0.362	0.451	0.550	0.788

Note: CAD = Constructive Authenticity of Dubrovnik; CAK = Constructive Authenticity of King's Landing; EA = Existential Authenticity; FP = Fantasy Proneness; DL = Destination Loyalty; OAD = Objective Authenticity of Dubrovnik; OAK = Objective Authenticity of King's Landing.

Measurement Model

Findings from the close-ended questions are discussed in the this and following sections. First, factor analysis was conducted to identify the underlying dimensions of the self-developed items on two constructs: (1) the objective authenticity of Dubrovnik and (2) the objective authenticity of King's Landing. Using principal axis factoring and oblique factor rotation, the analysis generated two factors with satisfying indicators: (1) Kaiser–Meyer–Olkin = 0.828, (2) Bartlett's test of sphericity = 2137.170 ($p = 0.000$), (3) total variance explained = 64.37%. Considering the meaning of the items in each factor, such results suggested that the data were suitable for identifying factor dimensions.

The testing of the hypotheses was conducted by partial least squares structural equation modelling (PLS-SEM, using SmartPLS 3.0). The sample size of 460 was deemed adequate after considering the largest number of structural paths directed toward a construct, that is, the power analysis (Hair et al. 2017) and the inverse square root method (Kock and Hadaya 2018). A two-stage analytical procedure was applied to first assess the measurement model, then the structural model.

The measurement model was assessed by multiple methods to evaluate the criteria of reliability, convergent validity, as well as discriminant validity (Hair et al. 2017). First, the evaluation of reliability was conducted in several steps. Following Hair et al.'s (2017) guidelines, outer loadings of all items were checked, and two items were removed due to

outer loadings lower than the threshold of 0.4, namely, FP3 (0.135) and FP4 (0.182). They were both reverse items (listed in Table 2), which could be the reason for their low reliability, as such items can be subject to mis-responses (Weijters and Baumgartner 2012). After comparing the content of the six items of the fantasy proneness construct, it was found that the remaining four items had sufficient coverage of the domain of the construct. Then the reliability test result on all retained items in Table 4 showed that (1) Cronbach's alpha for all measures were above the recommended threshold value of 0.7 (Hair et al. 2017), and (2) composite reliability for all measures were above the recommended cut-off point of 0.7 (Bagozzi and Yi 1988). Therefore, all measures were robust in terms of their reliability.

Second, the average variance extracted (AVE) values were found to be higher than the recommended cut-off value of 0.5 (Table 4), which suggested adequate convergent validity (Hair et al. 1998).

Third, the discriminant validity was assessed in two steps. First, it was assessed by checking whether the square roots of the AVE values for each construct were higher than the correlations between the respective constructs and the other constructs (Fornell and Larcker 1981). Table 5 shows that these criteria were met. Second, it was assessed by examining whether the loadings of any items on the expected variables were higher than the other loadings. The data presented in the cross-loading table (Table 6) demonstrate that all of the item loadings were higher on the expected factors than on the

Table 6. Loadings and Cross-Loadings of the Measurement Items.

ITEMS	OAK	OAD	CAD	CAK	EA	DL	FP
OAK1	0.820	0.500	0.509	0.604	0.314	0.414	0.294
OAK2	0.800	0.485	0.487	0.604	0.336	0.386	0.259
OAK3	0.785	0.395	0.456	0.636	0.406	0.346	0.263
OAK4	0.745	0.345	0.440	0.621	0.381	0.268	0.327
OAD1	0.441	0.813	0.529	0.247	0.090	0.654	0.040
OAD2	0.385	0.683	0.436	0.214	0.019	0.555	0.013
OAD3	0.424	0.774	0.498	0.247	0.093	0.610	0.095
OAD4	0.490	0.891	0.583	0.392	0.200	0.623	0.117
CAD1	0.453	0.577	0.716	0.415	0.205	0.496	0.184
CAD2	0.421	0.375	0.736	0.579	0.410	0.421	0.297
CAD3	0.520	0.555	0.868	0.560	0.407	0.564	0.312
CAK1	0.723	0.336	0.548	0.861	0.422	0.367	0.304
CAK2	0.629	0.282	0.588	0.840	0.502	0.315	0.323
CAK3	0.675	0.295	0.600	0.892	0.512	0.354	0.384
EA1	0.374	0.137	0.409	0.481	0.875	0.284	0.442
EA2	0.391	0.086	0.335	0.449	0.805	0.212	0.429
DL1	0.343	0.598	0.520	0.333	0.283	0.806	0.175
DL2	0.416	0.609	0.559	0.343	0.222	0.883	0.118
FP1	0.242	0.025	0.210	0.262	0.362	0.108	0.666
FP2	0.269	0.153	0.213	0.198	0.313	0.164	0.638
FP5	0.261	0.049	0.245	0.376	0.457	0.064	0.806
FP6	0.294	0.140	0.331	0.295	0.380	0.176	0.812

Note: OAK = Objective Authenticity of King's Landing; OAD = Objective Authenticity of Dubrovnik; CAD = Constructive Authenticity of Dubrovnik; CAK = Constructive Authenticity of King's Landing; EA = Existential Authenticity; DL = Destination Loyalty; FP = Fantasy Proneness.

other factors, thereby providing additional support for discriminant validity (Chin 1998).

To assess the severity of the common method bias, the Harman's single-factor test was employed to check the variances accounted for by the first factors generated from factor analysis of all the items. The result was 34.31%, which was less than half of the variance, signalling that common method bias was not a concern.

Structural Model

Before testing the structural model, it was imperative to assess whether multi-collinearity had occurred. The blind-folding test (omission distance = 7) reported satisfactory predictive accuracy, with Q2 values above 0. Additionally, the largest variance inflation factors were below 5 (3.90), which indicated that multicollinearity was not a concern.

The structural model results are presented in Figure 2, with the details presented in Table 7. Supporting hypotheses 1a and 1b, both the *Objective Authenticity of Dubrovnik* (coefficient = 0.555, $p = 0.000$) and the *Constructive Authenticity of Dubrovnik* (coefficient = 0.182, $p = 0.000$) were found to be significantly associated with behavioral intentions for destination loyalty. On the contrary, the *Objective Authenticity of King's Landing* (coefficient = -0.051 , $p = 0.338$) and the *Constructive Authenticity of King's Landing* (coefficient = 0.051, $p = 0.301$) were found

to be insignificantly associated with behavioral intentions for destination loyalty. Therefore, hypotheses 2a and 2b were not supported. Supporting hypothesis 3, *Existential Authenticity* (coefficient = 0.114, $p = 0.015$) was found to be significantly associated with behavioral intentions for destination loyalty, at the 0.05 level. The R^2 for *Destination Loyalty* was 0.648, which suggested that all five constructs together explained 64.8% of the variance in the construct of *Loyalty*.

In terms of the influence of constructive authenticity on *Existential Authenticity*, both the *Constructive Authenticity of Dubrovnik* (coefficient = 0.141, $p = 0.006$) and the *Constructive Authenticity of King's Landing* (coefficient = 0.398, $p = 0.000$) were found to be significant influencers, thereby supporting hypotheses 4a and 4b. The R^2 for *Existential Authenticity* was 0.313, which suggested that these two constructive authenticity constructs together explained 31.3% of the variance in the construct of *Existential Authenticity*.

Last, *Fantasy Proneness* was found to be significantly associated with both the *Constructive Authenticity of King's Landing* (coefficient = 0.341, $p = 0.000$) and the *Objective Authenticity of King's Landing* (coefficient = 0.307, $p = 0.000$), thereby supporting hypotheses 5a and 5b. *Fantasy Proneness* was also found to have explained 15.2% of the variance in the *Constructive Authenticity of King's Landing* and 12.8% of the variance in the *Objective Authenticity of King's Landing*.

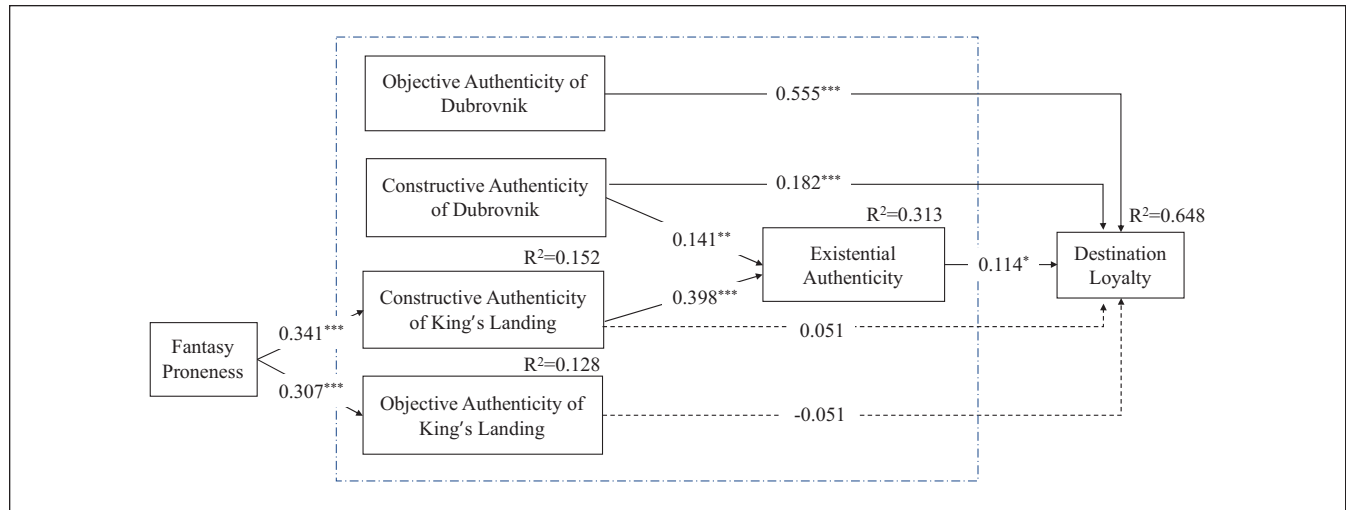


Figure 2. The Structural Model Estimation Results.

Note: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$; statistically significant paths are shown as solid lines, and non-significant paths are shown as dotted lines.

Table 7. Hypotheses Testing Results ($N = 460$).

	Path Coefficients	t Values	P Values	Bias-Corrected CIs	Hypotheses Testing
Hypothesis 1a. OAD → DL	0.555	12.014	0.000	[0.461, 0.639]	Supported
Hypothesis 1b. CAD → DL	0.182	3.766	0.000	[0.088, 0.288]	Supported
Hypothesis 2a. OAK → DL	-0.051	0.959	0.338	[-0.164, 0.055]	Not Supported
Hypothesis 2b. CAK → DL	0.051	1.035	0.301	[-0.044, 0.146]	Not Supported
Hypothesis 3. EA → DL	0.114	2.444	0.015	[0.023, 0.201]	Supported
Hypothesis 4a. CAD → EA	0.141	2.758	0.006	[0.033, 0.242]	Supported
Hypothesis 4b. CAK → EA	0.398	7.776	0.000	[0.288, 0.496]	Supported
Hypothesis 5a. FP → CAK	0.341	7.498	0.000	[0.246, 0.428]	Supported
Hypothesis 5b. FP → OAK	0.307	6.735	0.000	[0.222, 0.389]	Supported

Note: OAK = Objective Authenticity of King's Landing; OAD = Objective Authenticity of Dubrovnik; CAD = Constructive Authenticity of Dubrovnik; CAK = Constructive Authenticity of King's Landing; EA = Existential Authenticity; DL = Destination Loyalty; FP = Fantasy Proneness.

Discussion and Conclusion

This study has investigated the interplay of relationships between fantasy proneness, three types of authenticity and destination loyalty at on-screen tourism destinations with dual images. Using *Game of Thrones* as a case, the study compares the perceived authenticity of the two images representing King's Landing (the capital city of *Game of Thrones*) and its filming location, Dubrovnik. Specifically, this study builds a theoretical framework of authenticity to conceptualize and empirically evaluate the relationships between fantasy proneness, authenticity, and destination loyalty, as observed in an on-screen tourism context. In particular, the study examines how different types of authenticity can predict loyalty to an on-screen tourism destination.

The findings of the qualitative stage indicated that tourists perceive both Dubrovnik and King's Landing as authentic. Such findings might reflect the existence of displacement in the on-screen tourism context (i.e., the location and the setting are different). The results of the main quantitative study

also indicated that both the objective and the constructive authenticity of Dubrovnik were significantly and positively associated with destination loyalty, but perceptions regarding these two types of authenticity concerning King's Landing were not directly related to loyalty. This set of findings implied that the real place may play a more important role than the film location in attracting revisits. These results were consistent with the findings of Ivanovic (2014), which showed that tourists' foremost source of perceived authenticity was the urban, historical, and cultural heritage of the place concerned. This might be because although the media fiction may initially motivate some tourists visiting the filming location and on the arrival of the destination, they may compare between the film location and the story setting (Reijnders 2011). It could be that authentic attributes, such as architecture, history, and culture in real Dubrovnik are more likely to be associated with destination loyalty. This is also observed in pre-stage interviews. For example, one of our interviewees expressed that "I first got to know about

Dubrovnik after watching *Game of Thrones* and then decided to travel to that city. When I got there, I was so impressed by its historical architecture and started to learn about its culture and history. I loved this place and recommended it to my friends through WeChat.”

Although no direct connection was found between authenticity of King’s Landing and destination loyalty, constructive authenticity of King’s landing is indirectly related to loyalty through contributing to existential authenticity together with constructive authenticity of Dubrovnik (see Figure 2). This implies that associating with the historical character, lifestyle of people, and culture of King’s Landing is likely to achieve the existential state of being, that is, pursuing self-realization or self-satisfaction, setting one’s body free from the limitations of daily routines. This eventually leads to future revisitations and recommendations of Dubrovnik to others.

It is suggested that tourism companies including travel agents and attractions can try to provide tourists authentic tastes of King’s Landing. For example, a role-play entertainment activity has been recommended by Gothie (2016). Tourists may dress up in fictional characters’ costumes and experience famous scenes, for example, battles or weddings or characters’ lives as portrayed in *Game of Thrones*. At the same time, it should be careful not to become a commodified place, risking diluting the original meaning of culture and symbols of history in Dubrovnik (Lichrou, O’Malley, and Patterson 2017). In other words, there needs to be a balance between staging authenticity of King’s Landing and reflecting authenticity of Dubrovnik. In fact, marketing experts may produce a combined promotional brochure providing a taste of the real history, culture, and scenery of the real place and a touch of characters and scenes of the fictions shown on screen (Selwyn 1990).

The objective authenticity of Dubrovnik, stemming from the museum-linked sense of authenticity (N. Wang 1999), was found to rely mainly on “staged representations” of the history, culture, architecture, and landscape of Dubrovnik, as perceived by the tourists. This set of findings implies that tourists are inclined to accept the “staged authenticity” of Dubrovnik as promoted by marketers. This is also supported by Trilling’s (1972) explanation of authenticity to be primitive. Tourism bureaus may make an effort to present and preserve the pure nature (e.g., the blue sea) and the pristine (e.g., the ancient city wall) as the natural and the pristine are authentic features that tourists seek for (Cohen 1988). The constructive authenticity of Dubrovnik, which was assessed on the basis of a poststructuralist context (Waitt 2000), mainly concerned the socially constructed interpretation of Dubrovnik’s past. Constructive authenticity can be formed by different stakeholders (Zhu 2012). Among these stakeholders, tourists are considered as a crucial group for interpreting the authenticity of Dubrovnik. Getz (1994, p. 319) considered authenticity as “a measure of the tourist’s perceptions.” Therefore, it suggests that policy makers and marketers should enable and encourage tourists to take an active

role in constructing authenticity. This may be achieved by understanding tourists’ interpretation of the real Dubrovnik and its history and then incorporating tourists’ needs in the creation of new meanings of the on-screen tourism destination, the transformation of its image and the design of tourism products. To understand tourists’ authentic experience would allow the on-screen destination to incorporate tourists’ interpretations of the destinations in the marketing materials and make an optimal investment decision (Jiang et al. 2017).

The findings of this study indicate that “cool” authentication, which is relevant to object authenticity, is more closely related to destination loyalty. “Cool” authentication requires marketers to enhance the image of a tourism destination, and to differentiate it from other destinations through “authenticating them as either reflecting the Other (‘othering’) or some pre-modern tradition” (Cohen and Cohen 2012, p. 1300). Thus, this study’s findings suggest that it is important to communicate a strong, clear, and authentic image of Dubrovnik as a World Heritage Site. According to the results of the open-ended questions on the perceived authenticity of Dubrovnik, particular emphasis was placed on the top perceived authentic characteristics of Dubrovnik, including the city’s history, wall, architecture, city streets, and landscapes. A practical implication is that the historical wall, the architecture, and the old town of Dubrovnik can be displayed and marketed as if they were museum objects, dating back to the most representative historical time when Dubrovnik was the capital of the maritime Republic of Ragusa.

The findings of this study revealed that existential authenticity is positively associated with destination loyalty, which is partially consistent with previous findings. In using the same consumer-based model, some studies found that existential authenticity was positively related to loyalty (e.g., Kolar and Zabkar 2010; Fu 2019), but this relationship was found insignificant in the research by Zhou, Zhang, and Edelman (2013). It seems that the relationship between these two variables can vary between cases.

Our findings indicate that the objective and the constructive authenticity of Dubrovnik and its perceived existential authenticity all play important roles in attracting tourists’ revisits to the destination and in motivating tourists to recommend the destination to others. These findings suggest caution toward arguments that assessments of existential authenticity should replace assessments of the two types of object authenticity (Reisinger and Steiner 2006). Conversely, both types of authenticity are important in on-screen tourism. Our findings also suggest that both object authenticity and existential authenticity “not only coexist but also are significantly related”, so that both types of authenticity need to be examined concurrently, as argued by Kolar and Zabkar (2010). In line with the previous literature (N. Wang 1999; Kolar and Zabkar 2010; Yi et al. 2018), the findings show that perceptions of constructive authenticity regarding both Dubrovnik and King’s Landing are positively associated

with existential authenticity. It may imply that tourists perceive authenticity by focusing on their expectations and inspirations in assessing both the heritage city, Dubrovnik, and the fictional city, King's Landing. In addition, it suggests that either set of images can trigger tourists' sense of authenticity in terms of feeling true to themselves.

To effectively improve tourists' destination loyalty, destination managers and marketers need to consider tourists' perceptions toward different types of authenticity. This is particularly important when the destination tells two tales (i.e., the on-screen tale and the real place tale). Apart from King's Landing/Dubrovnik, other on-screen tourism destinations also show dual images, such as New Zealand and Middle-Earth in *The Lord of the Rings* films (Buchmann 2010), the vampire-inhabited Forks, USA, and the *Twilight Saga* film series (Larson, Lundberg, and Lexhagen 2013), and a violent and drug-infested Medellin, Columbia, and Netflix series *Narcos* (Naef 2018). Moreover, the findings of the study shed some light on the authenticity issues at other tourism destinations that reveal both a realistic place and an imagined place if the location is associated with other forms of popular culture such as novels, for example, *Outlander* in Scotland (Cateridge 2018) and computer or virtual reality games such *Assassin's Creed* in Florence, Italy (Lamerichs 2018). The results of the study indicate that the object authenticity of the film location (e.g., Dubrovnik) is associated with destination loyalty, and thus efforts can be made to improve perceptions regarding this type of authenticity. One of these efforts can involve enhancing the inspiration offered by the site's historical heritage and architecture (e.g., the ports, forts, castles, and walls in Dubrovnik). These objects cannot speak for themselves, nor can tourists automatically identify these valuable authentic features. Therefore, these features can be made more enjoyable and engaging according to the manner they are displayed and introduced (Kolar and Zabkar 2010). For example, more interactive activities in museums can help to introduce the city's history.

The results show that the perceived authenticity of Dubrovnik is significantly associated with destination loyalty, but the perceived authenticity of King's Landing has an insignificant association with destination loyalty. These results suggest that tourism managers need to place more emphasis on the delivery and communication of the historical heritage site, rather than emphasizing the created history of King's Landing. This study also finds a strong relation between all types of object authenticity and existential authenticity. These findings indicate that managers should try to serve their tourists' existential quests. This kind of service may be achieved through creating extra-mundane or unusual experiences for tourists, and by seeking to set tourists apart from their daily routines. This type of approach can allow the tourists to experience a greater sense of pursuing their own self-realization and self-satisfaction.

This study also finds that fantasy proneness is strongly associated with perceptions of objective and constructive

authenticity regarding King's Landing. The highly fantasy-prone visitors tend to perceive stronger authenticity regarding the film location. This perception might arise because highly fantasy-prone people may be more likely to immerse themselves into the fictional worlds created by fantasy films and television shows. People who are highly fantasy prone may construct authenticity by framing what they believe is true about the film location. The findings of this study reveal that tourists who are highly fantasy prone are more likely to perceive authenticity at the film site for King's Landing. This kind of perception is linked to higher levels of existential authenticity, and it may further influence destination loyalty. Thus, marketers for on-screen tourism destinations are advised to include marketing strategies for tourists with high levels of fantasy proneness. For example, images together with texts regarding the relevant films and television series can be used to arouse the mental imagery of highly fantasy-prone tourists.

The 2020 COVID-19 pandemic and its resulting global quarantine enforcement and restrictions on travel was followed by a massive increase in popular culture consumption (Blumberg 2020). This consumption has allowed people to escape reality and experience new places while still adhering to safety regulations in the comfort of their homes, made possible by streaming services such as Netflix, Amazon Prime, and HBO. This showcases the important link between screen productions and people's need/wish to visit new places and universes in times when physical travel is impossible (Lee et al. 2018). Managers, marketers, and policy makers in the hospitality and tourism industry should therefore take this opportunity to explore new ways of capitalizing on their destinations' possible associations with popular culture phenomena that can drive future travel, physically and digitally, in a tourism future facing the long-term effects of the pandemic.

The study did not distinguish between different types of tourists in the analysis. It could be interesting for future research projects to further explore the relationships between authenticity and behavioral intention from perspectives of different types of tourists in other tourism destinations where a film or television series has been produced. Another limitation of this article is that it focuses only on the relationship between authenticity and destination loyalty, including revisitation intention and recommendation to friends. Perceived authenticity of film locations and story setting may be also related to destination image and satisfaction, which is worth further examinations. Moreover, because of the research aim, this study did not explore different types of motivations to visit an on-screen tourism destination. Future research can include visit motivations in the model and further explore the relationship of different types of authenticity. For example, if tourists visited on-screen tourism destination because of watching the associated on-screen products, then it can evaluate how perceived authenticity of the film location influence perceived authenticity of the real place.

Appendix

Interview Guide for the Pre-Stage Study
Interviewee's demographic background:

Gender
Age
Nationality
Occupation
Education
How many times have you been to Dubrovnik?
Which series of *Game of Thrones* have you watched?

1. Can you please describe your experience of visiting Dubrovnik?
2. What do you perceive as the main authentic characteristics of Dubrovnik? Why do you perceive these as the main authentic characteristics of Dubrovnik?
3. What do you perceive as the main authentic characteristics of King's Landing? Why do you perceive these as the main authentic characteristics of King's Landing?
4. During your visit to Dubrovnik, can you tell the difference between authentic characteristics of Dubrovnik and King's Landing?
5. Would you like to visit Dubrovnik again and Why?
6. Will you recommend Dubrovnik to your friends and Why?

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